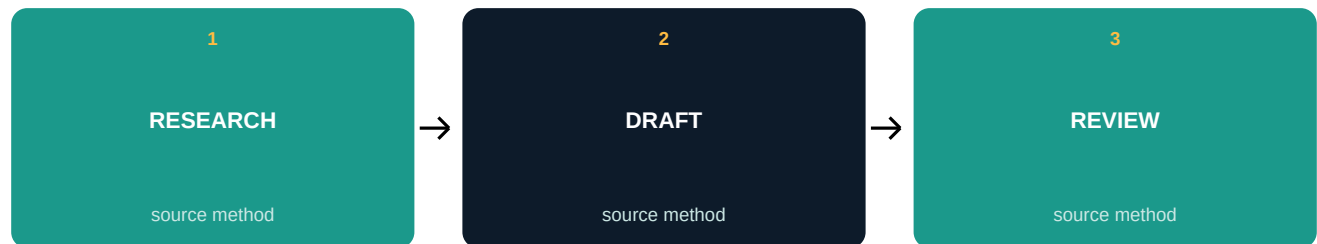


CHAPTER 16

When One Prompt Isn't Enough



THE SINGLE - PROMPT CEILING For simple, well-defined tasks, summarise this, draft that, answer this question, a single well-crafted prompt is usually sufficient. But professional work is rarely simple and well-defined.

A business proposal is not one task. It is: research the client, understand their problem, frame the approach, develop the argument, structure the document, draft each section, review for consistency, check for gaps, refine the language, and produce a final version. Each of these is a distinct cognitive task that benefits from distinct treatment.

Attempting to produce a business proposal in a single prompt produces a generic outline at best and a generic document at worst. Neither is what you needed.

The ceiling of single-prompt AI use is low. Most professional work requires workflows.

WHAT MAKES SOMETHING A WORKFLOW A workflow, for our purposes, is any AI task that:

Involves more than one distinct phase (research, then structure, then draft, then review) Produces output that becomes input to the next stage Benefits from human review and adjustment at one or more stages Is too complex for a single prompt to handle well

Most significant pieces of work, proposals, reports, analyses, plans, complex communications, are workflows. The shift to thinking in workflows is one of the biggest quality improvements available to regular AI users.

WHY BREAKING TASKS INTO STAGES WORKS When you ask AI to do too many things at once, it compromises on everything. The research is superficial because the prompt also asked for structure. The draft is generic because the prompt also asked for analysis. The analysis is shallow because the prompt also asked for recommendations.

Breaking a task into stages allows AI to do each stage well, with appropriate depth and focus. It also allows you to review and adjust at each stage before committing the next stage to an approach that might be wrong.

The best analogy is professional practice: a good architect doesn't hand you the construction drawings at the first meeting. They produce a brief, then a concept, then a scheme, then detailed drawings, each stage reviewed and approved before the next begins.



THE THREE MOST COMMON MULTI-STAGE PATTERNS

THE RESEARCH-PLAN-DRAFT PATTERN Stage 1: Research and gather information. Stage 2: Plan the structure. Stage 3: Draft the content.

This is the most universally useful workflow. Almost any document benefits from separating the gathering of content from the writing of it.

THE DRAFT-REVIEW-REFINE PATTERN Stage 1: Produce a complete draft. Stage 2: Review the draft against explicit criteria. Stage 3: Refine based on the review.

This is particularly valuable because Stage 2 uses a different cognitive mode than Stage 1. Writing mode and editing mode are different, and separating them, even within AI, produces better results.

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THE DECOMPOSE-EXECUTE-ASSEMBLE PATTERN Stage 1: Break a large task into components. Stage 2: Execute each component separately. Stage 3: Assemble the components.

This is most useful for large documents or complex outputs where different sections require different content or expertise.



PART IV - FROM PROMPTS TO WORKFLOWS

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE David needs to produce a quarterly business review for his consultancy's three largest clients.

Single-prompt approach: "Write a quarterly business review for Client X." Result: A generic template that David has to fill in entirely himself.

WORKFLOW APPROACH: Stage 1: "I'm going to paste in my notes from the last three months of client interactions, plus their project status reports. Extract: key achievements, challenges faced, decisions made, and open items. Present as a structured list, not prose."

David reviews the extraction, adds two items AI missed, removes one that was irrelevant.

Stage 2: "Using the extracted information, create a narrative structure for the quarterly review. Three sections: What We Achieved, What We Learned, and What Comes Next. For each section, suggest what the key two or three points should be."

David adjusts the suggested structure, moves one point to a different section, adds a point AI didn't suggest.

Stage 3: "Now draft the quarterly review document using the structure we agreed. Professional tone, plain language, about 800 words. The client is the owner and will share it with their management team."

The resulting document is specific, accurate, and usable. It took less time than the single-prompt version and produced dramatically better output, not because AI was better, but because the workflow allowed human judgment to guide it at each stage.

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WHY IT WORKS MULTI-STAGE WORKFLOWS WORK FOR THE SAME REASON THAT PROFESSIONAL PROCESSES WORK

each stage has a clear purpose, a clear deliverable, and a defined handoff point. Breaking work into stages allows you to catch errors before they compound. It allows you to apply different types of thinking to different types of sub-tasks. And it allows AI to do each sub-task well rather than doing all sub-tasks adequately.



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